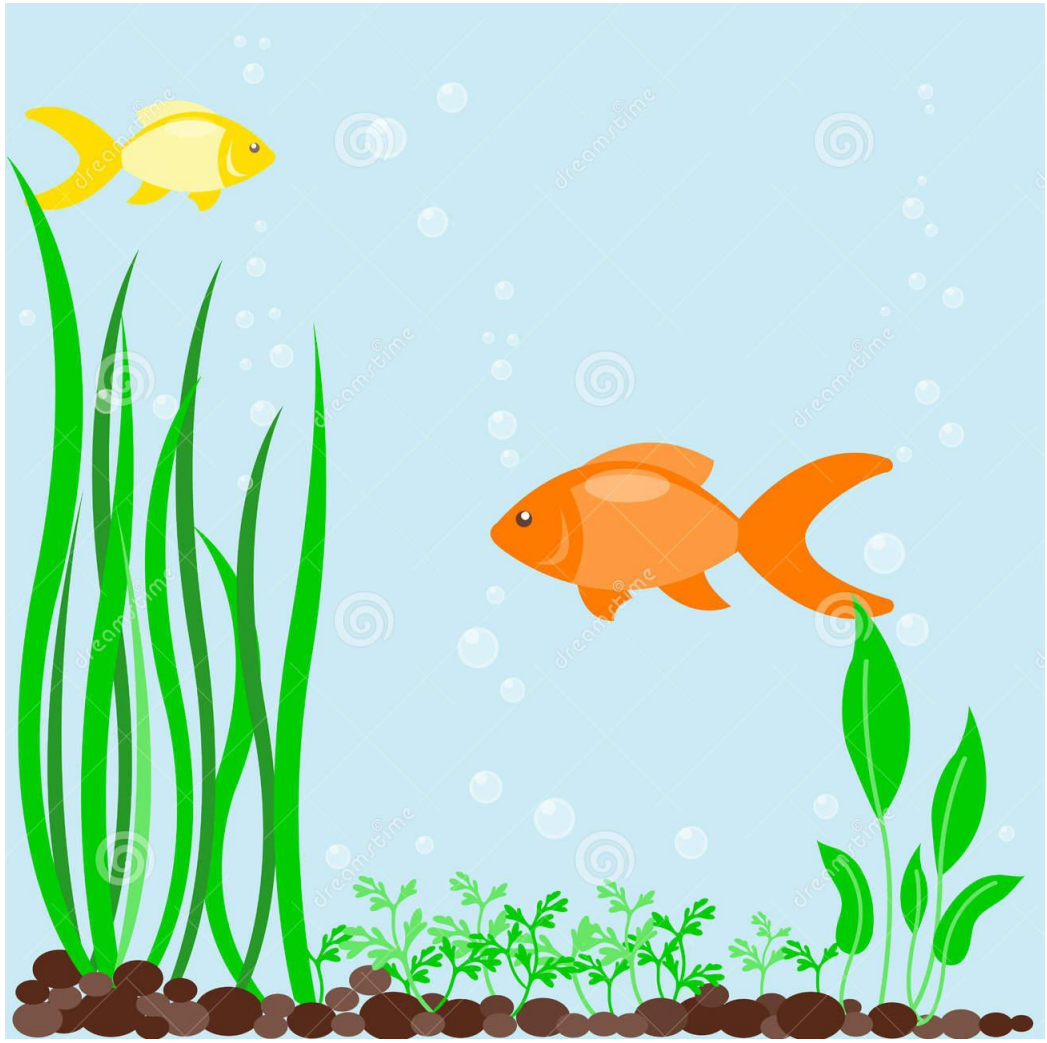
How Culture Influences the Self

Cristina Salvador

Duke University

What is Culture?



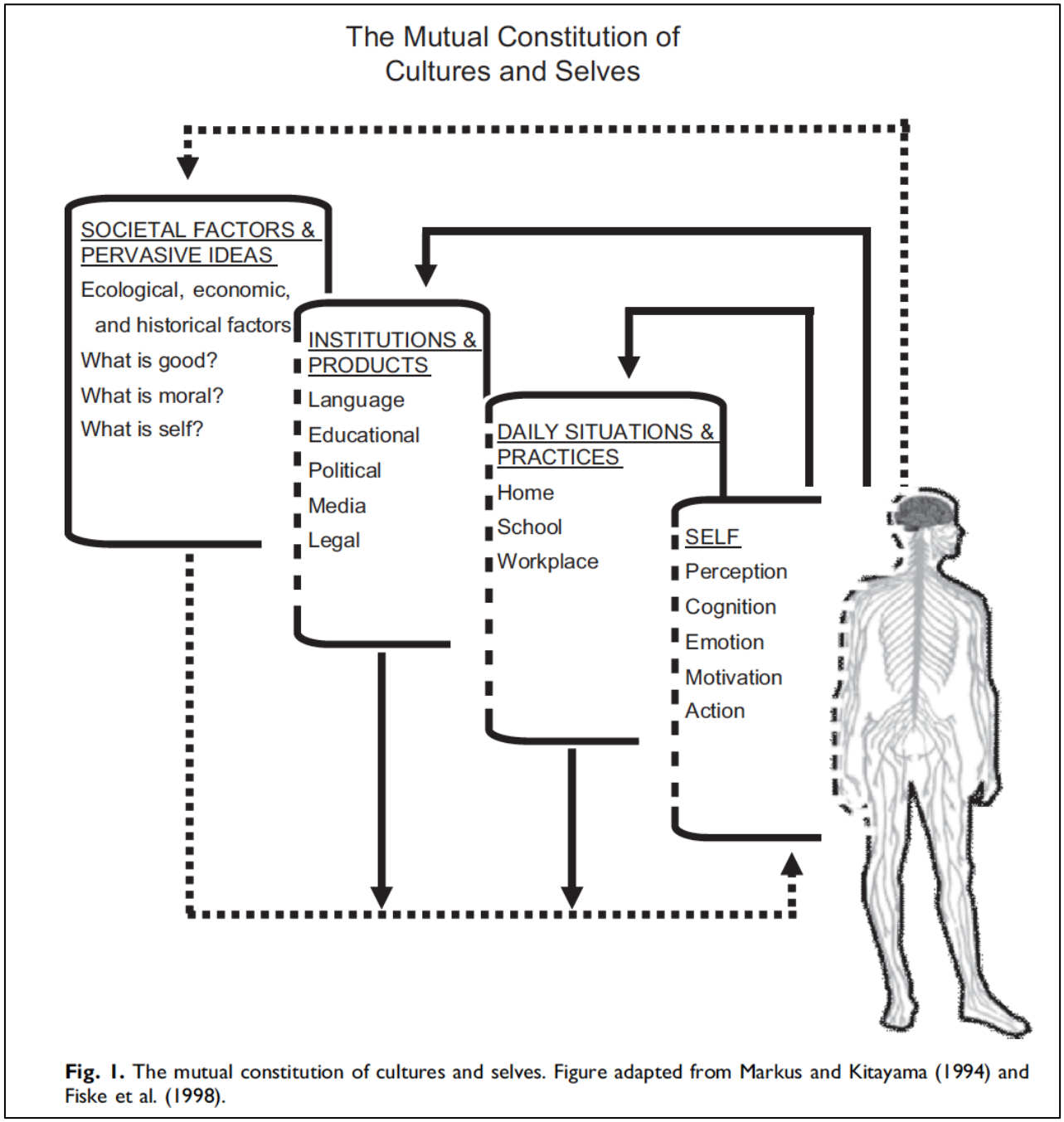


Fig. 1. The mutual constitution of cultures and selves. Figure adapted from Markus and Kitayama (1994) and Fiske et al. (1998).

Markus & Kitayama, 2010, *Perspectives on Psychological Science*

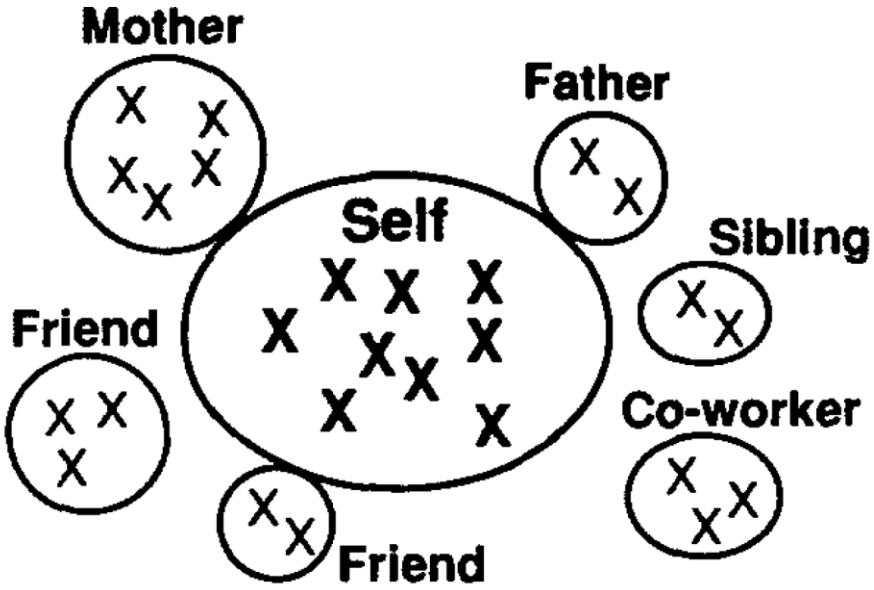
What is Culture?

- Culture is composed of a set of *tasks* (what to do and how to do it; sometimes called “practices”)
  - *meanings* of these tasks (what it means)

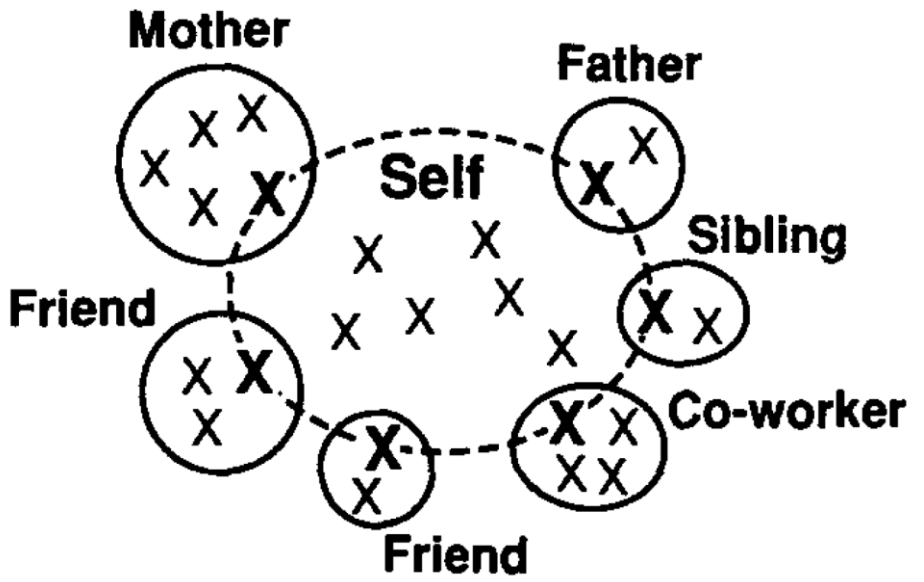
- They are also unevenly distributed within each tradition/group

- What are some of the biggest cultural differences you notice?

Independence/Interdependence



A. Independent View of Self



B. Interdependent View of Self

WEIRD

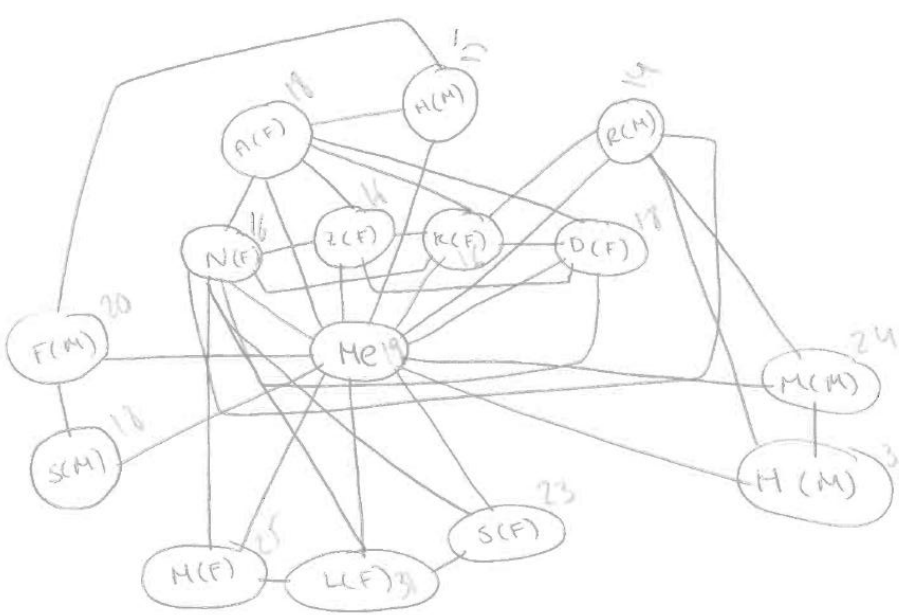
(Henrich et al., 2010, Behavioral and Brain Sciences)

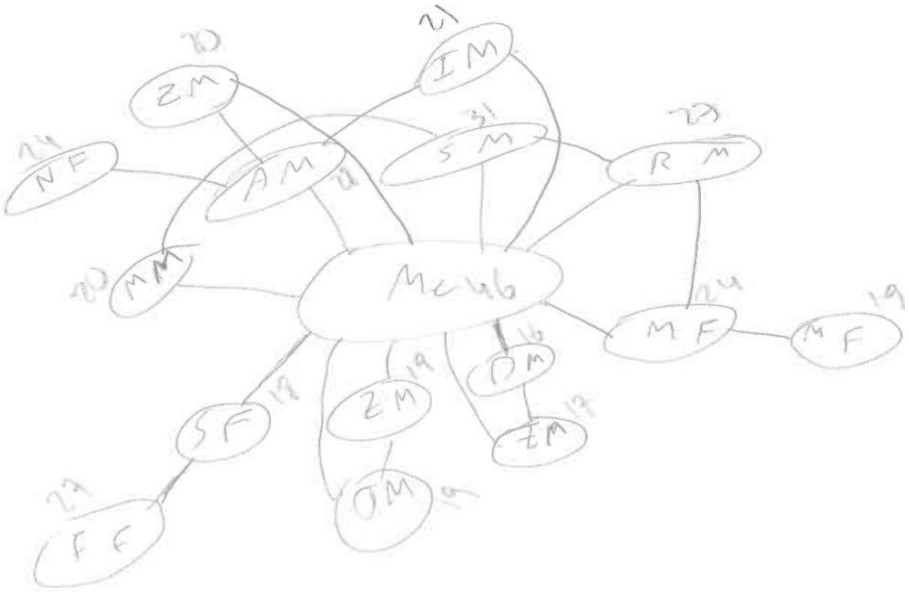
Non-WEIRD

East Asians, Indians, Arabs and Latin Americans

Markus & Kitayama, 1991, Psychological Review

Activity





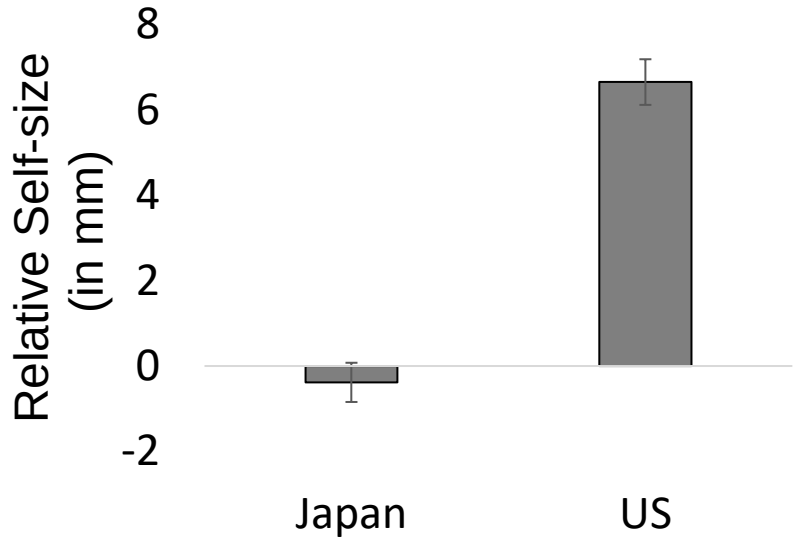
Kitayama et. al., 2009, *JPSP;* San Martin et al., 2018, *Nature Human Behavior*

What can the sociogram tell us about culture?

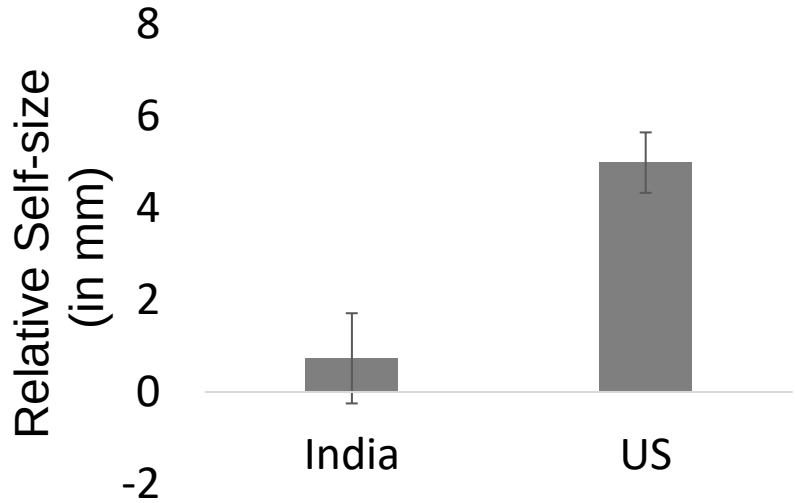
What are your hypotheses?

Culture & self-enhancement

Cultural Group	Self
European Americans	Self-enhancing
East Asians	Self-critical
Indians	Self-critical



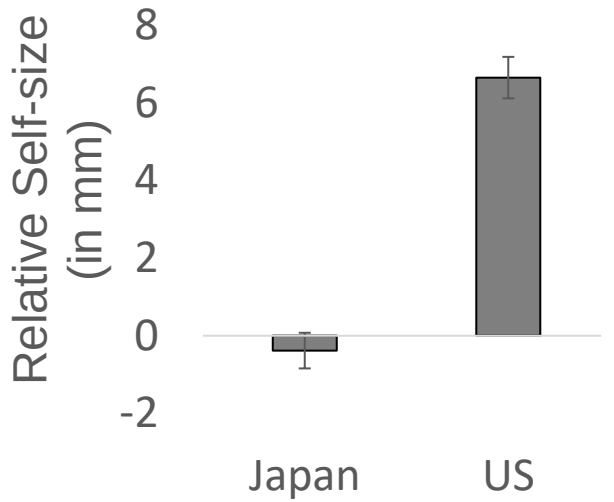
Salvador et al., 2025, *Personality & Social Psychology Bulletin*



Nanakdewa, Savani, Salvador et al., in revision

Culture & self-enhancement

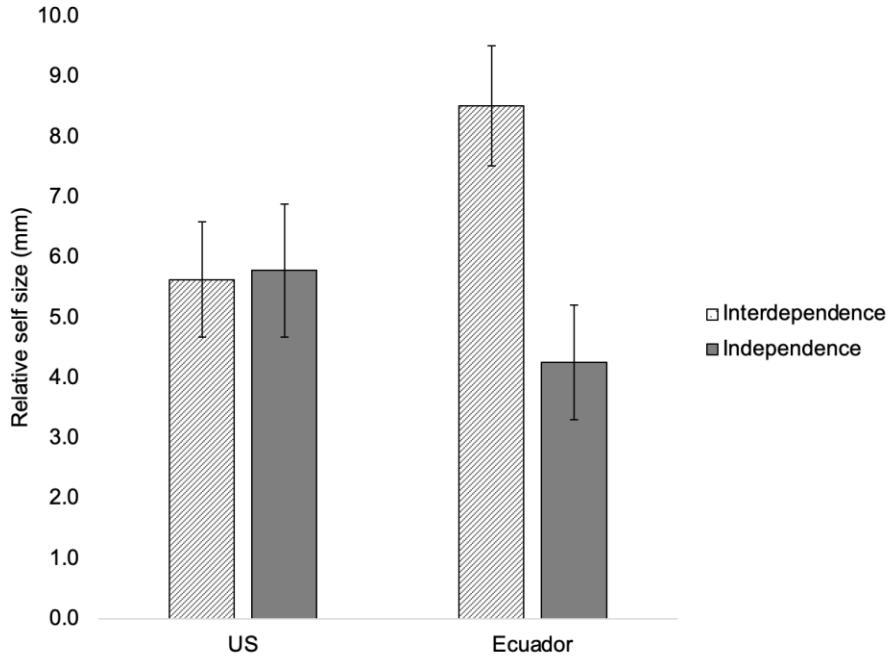
Cultural Group	Self
European Americans	Self-enhancing
East Asians	Self-critical
Indians	Self-critical
Arabs	Self-enhancing
Latin Americans	Self-enhancing



Salvador et al., 2025, *Personality & Social Psychology Bulletin*

Are all self-enhancing cultures the same?

- Are Arabs and Latin Americans less interdependent than East Asians?
  - Similarities and Differences (San Martin et al., 2018)



Salvador et al., 2025, *Personality & Social Psychology Bulletin*

What would you think would happen in your culture?

Would these findings replicate?

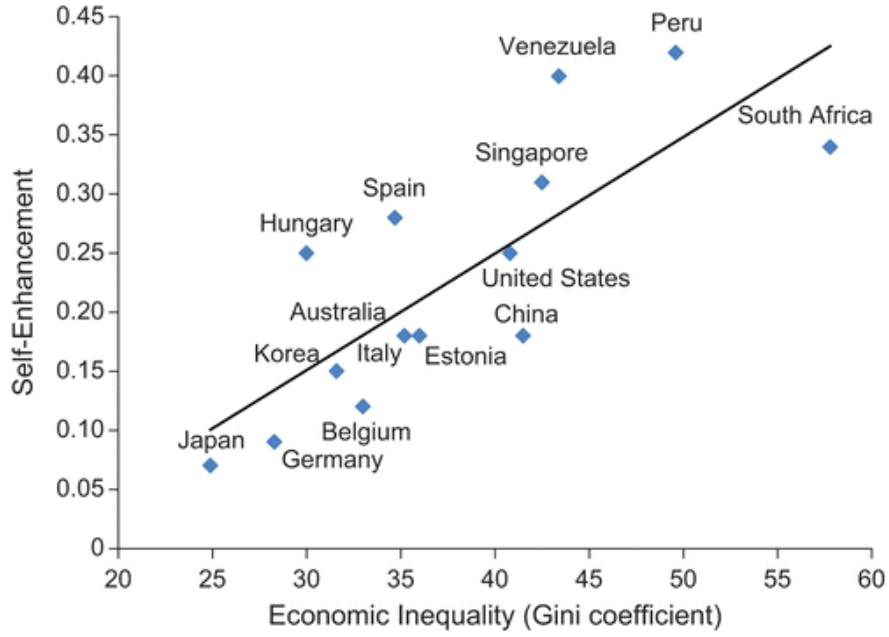
Summary

- Culture shapes the self
- Cultures vary substantially in self-enhancement
- East Asians and Indians are self-critical
  - “The nail that sticks out gets pounded down”
  - Adjust the self to fit in to social relations
- European Americans, Arabs and Latin Americans are self-enhancing
  - “The squeaky wheel gets the grease”

Summary

- Motivations for self-enhancement differ
  - Assert positive uniqueness of the self
  - Ingroup protection

- Why do you think these differences arise?

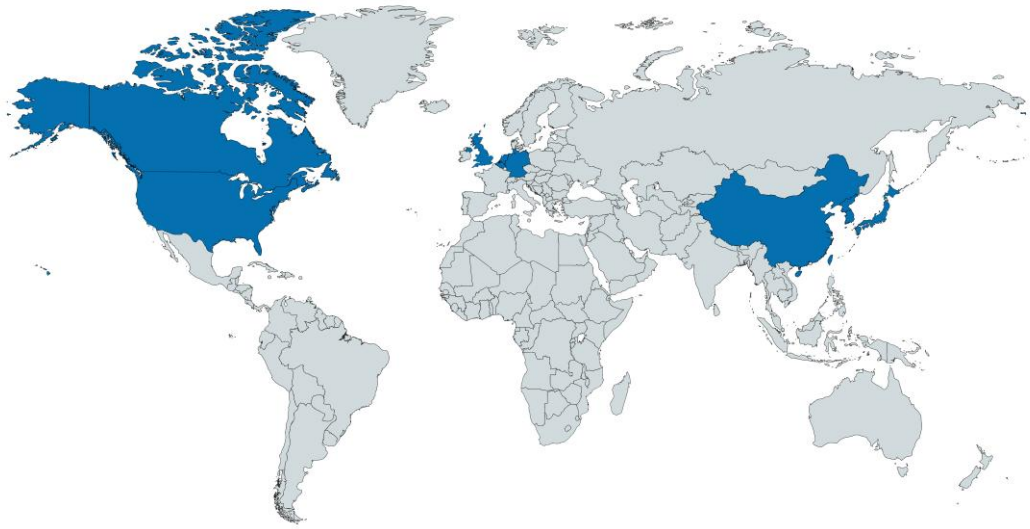


Loughann et al., 2011, Psychological Science

Most of what we know about interdependence is based on East Asia

- The valued state of interdependence may be achieved through multiple pathways

- Varieties of interdependence



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, American Psychologist
Kitayama & Salvador, 2024, Annual Review of Psychology

Conflict Avoidance

- Tightly organized societies with little apparent conflict
- Maintenance of social harmony by avoiding social conflict
  - Self-effacement/criticism vs. self-enhancement
- Typically found in East Asia
  - Emotional suppression is common
  - Argument is avoided
  - Compromise is valued
  - Self-effacement



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, *American Psychologist*

Ingroup Protection

- Nomadic life in desert, full of danger of exploitation by outgroups (raids by neighboring tribes)
- Strong self that is seen as a virtue for the sake of ingroup protection
  - Self-assertion/enhancement
- Common in Arabs (in the tradition of the nomadic Bedouin)
  - Self-assertion/enhancement is very pronounced (San Martin et al., 2018)



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, *American Psychologist*

Emotional Expression

- Multi-racial, ethnic, and linguistic community
- Need for emotional communication

- Emotional resonance – sharing feelings without words
  - "Simpatia"

-Emotional expression
  - Particularly positive and interpersonally engaging emotions (Salvador et al., 2023, Emotion)



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, *American Psychologist*

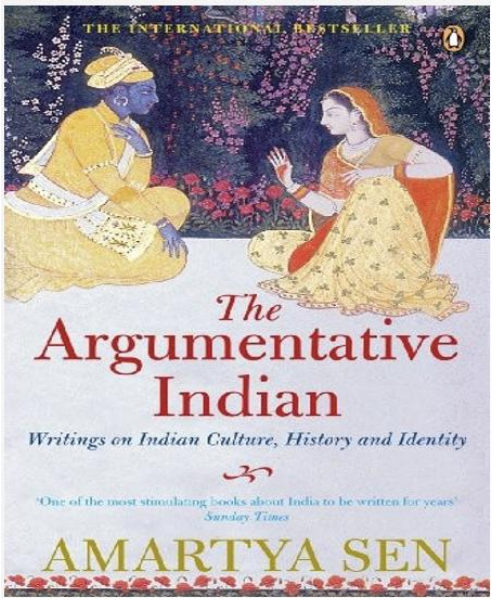
Argumentation

- Commercial centers in a wide range of areas from the Mediterranean to South Asia

- Means for addressing and resolving business conflicts

- Aristotlean logic as a means for conflict resolution

- Argumentative (Lu et al., 2020, JPSP)
- Analytic thinking style but self-effacing (Nanakdewa, Salvador et al., under review)



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, *American Psychologist*

The Emergence of the Modern West

- Self-assertion of Arabs and self-promotion
  - Ingroup protection to assertion of the independent self
  - Self and other promotion to promotion of the self
- Emotional expression of Latin culture
  - Ingroup communication to expression of the inner soul (Rousseau)
- Argumentation and logical thinking
  - Conflict resolution to Expression of pure, independent reason



Kitayama, Salvador et al., 2022, *American Psychologist*

Summary

- People vary in how much they view the self as independent or interdependent.

- The non-West is diverse and there are are many varieties of interdependence.
  - Depending on the ecology & history of a place how they achieve interdependence will vary.

  - The same psychological tendency that promotes independence in one culture can promote interdependence in another.

    - Example of self-enhancement